6.6 The Security Panel

Windows Vista's Security Panel offers a unified place to access and modify all the operating system's security settings. It is also the place to go if you want to check up on the security status of your OS. While such a central console was first presented under Windows XP SP2, Vista's iteration is even more comprehensive and useful.

The panel can be found inside the Control Panel which in turn can be started from **Start > Control Panel**. Click on Security to open the Security panel. Before you do that, note how the Control Panel offers direct links to the most used tasks right under the "Security" heading:

The Control Panel

- Check for updates
- Check this computer's security status
- Allow a program through Windows Firewall

The Security Panel

Note the shield icon before "Allow a program...": this indicates that the task requires a UAC elevation to execute. Let's take a look at the various options available here—from top to bottom we have: